If the party had been looking to revive its fighting spirit, Rahul gave them ample reason for hope. ‘No matter how dark the night, India teaches you to fight on. We will go into this battle as warriors, with every single thing we have,’ he thundered. The audience of loyal Gandhi family supporters, for the moment at least, was electrified.

He stopped short of pronouncing himself as the party’s prime ministerial candidate, saying the Congress was a democratic party and the elected MPs would choose their leader. But there were enough hints that he had finally decided to shed his reluctance to take the plunge. ‘I am your soldier, I will do whatever you tell me,’ he said, as a rapturous audience cheered him on.

And if there was any doubt that a change in guard had been effected, it came when Rahul turned to the prime minister on the stage and almost ‘demanded’ of him, ‘Mr Prime Minister, nine subsidized LPG cylinders are not enough. This country’s women want twelve cylinders every year.’ Two weeks later, the UPA government tamely raised the quota of subsidized cooking gas cylinders from nine to twelve per household.

In the studio, we analysed the speech and felt that Rahul had finally come of age. The attack on Modi had been blistering, the kind you expect at election time. His stance and posture were of a man who saw himself as the Supreme Commander of his forces at last. Even the Hindi had noticeably improved, and was near flawless. Most analysts gave the performance eight on ten.

Had the election turned, we asked ourselves. Television likes instant judgements, and a bit of hyperbole—our verdict was that the speech could be a turning point in the fortunes of the Congress party. This, after all, was a party which was umbilically tied to one family. Finally, their yuvraj was showing some signs of stirring and taking charge.

It didn’t take long for the bubble to burst. That very morning at the party session, Mani Shankar Aiyar had given a sound bite to the news agency ANI, lashing out at Narendra Modi. Aiyar had a visceral hatred for Modi. In our studio discussions, almost foaming at the mouth, he would liken the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate to Hitler, and the RSS to the Nazis. Now, asked for his views on Modi, Aiyar shot back, ‘He can never be the prime